

AUSTRALIA AND PAPUA NEW GUINEA

SURROUNDED BY THE INDIAN and Pacific oceans, Australia is the world's smallest continent. It is vast, nearly the size of the US, and very dry. There is little rain, and arid desert stretches across about two-thirds of the land. Most of the people live in the big cities along the coasts. To the north, only 93 miles (150 km) across the Torres Strait, lies Papua New Guinea. An Australian colony until 1975, it consists of the eastern end of the island of New Guinea and more than 600 surrounding islands.



Raggiana's bird of paradise – two-thirds of all birds of paradise live in the forests of Papua New Guinea.

ISLAND OF MOUNTAINS AND FORESTS

Papua New Guinea lies entirely in the tropics and has a hot, wet climate. Running from west to east along the island is a range of high rugged mountains covered with dense rain forest. These remote forests are home to a vast range of plants and animals, many of which are found nowhere else in the world. Mangrove swamps grow along many of the island's coasts.



When rains do come, there are flash floods, and plants like this Sturt's Desert Pea flower from seeds that have lain dormant for years.

THE OUTBACK

Most of Australia is a flat plain without mountains, forests, or rivers. The huge central region, known as the outback, is one of the hottest and driest places on Earth. It has sandy or stony deserts, which can be baked by intense heat during the day and frozen by extreme cold at night. In places where there is some vegetation, or the land has been irrigated, farmers raise cattle and sheep.



ULURU

This massive block of sandstone stands almost in the middle of Australia. It measures 5.8 miles (9.4 km) around the base, and rises to 1,142 ft (348 m). To the Aborigines, the first people of Australia, the rock is known as Uluru. It is a sacred site and features in their beliefs about the creation of the world. Once called Ayers Rock after a former premier of South Australia, the rock regained its Aboriginal name in 1985.



GREAT BARRIER REEF

The Great Barrier Reef, the largest living thing on Earth, stretches for 1,243 miles (2,000 km) along the northeastern coast of Australia. It is the world's largest coral reef and home to more than 2,000 species of fish. Its coral is made of layer upon layer of tiny anemonelike creatures called polyps. The Great Barrier Reef is a major tourist attraction, but swimmers and divers can easily pollute and damage it. To protect it, the reef has been made a World Heritage Area.

